

and has the same low profile horizontal design. Samsung's ML-2245 is similar to ML-1640, but larger in dimensions. Canon's LBP-1210 has been around for a while, and its bulbous design feels dated.

Brother's HL-2150N comes equipped with inbuilt Ethernet network support, apart from the ubiquitous USB. All other printers offered only a USB 2.0 connector. Further, the HL-2150N comes with 16 MB of buffer memory as compared to 8 MB seen on the others. However, the higher memory doesn't seem to help the HL-2150N perform better. Canon's LBP-1210 had a Parallel port and as we said, this is an old printer from Canon—it's fast though.

Brother's HL-2150N and Canon's LBP-1210 had dedicated paper trays, and hence could hold 250 sheets. All the other printers had standard 150-sheet capacity trays. HP's P1008 also has a substantial 100 page sheet feeder, whereas Canon's LBP-1210 has a 10 page manual sheet feeder. None of these printers had automatic dual-side printing support; it's a feature which saves lot of paper.

Installing these printers was a breeze, and there were no problems. The driver interface is intuitive, and the settings can be changed without any fuss. There are pre-defined profiles which can be used with a single-click of the mouse. The driver allows extensive control over the device and also gives full details on the toner and drum life in all printers.

### Performance

HP's P1008 and P1007 set the performance benchmarking by delivering the first print—9 seconds flat. This was observed in all tests we put these two babies through—even when printing heavy documents, both the HP printers completed



Brother HL-2140

the job in just 13 seconds. In this speed run, Samsung's ML-2245 was just behind the HPs. Brother's HL-2150N took slightly longer than the other printers when printing heavy documents; otherwise its performance was on par with Samsung's ML-2245. Canon, despite being an older model, competed well with these new models, and was even faster than the Brother HL-2150N in some tests.

In print quality, Samsung's ML-2245 delivered sharp and well-detailed printouts. The ML-2245 was right up there with HP printers in most of the tests, and scored even better in some. The only area where the Samsung was well and truly beaten by the HP was when reproducing light shades of grey. Brother's HL-2150N delivered reasonably good printouts. Canon's LBP-1210 couldn't compete with these new age printers, we think it's about time Canon should pull the plug on the LBP-1210.

Samsung's ML-2245 is sensibly priced and given its terrific performance we award it our *Best Buy* award. HP's LaserJet P1007 takes the coveted *Editor's Pick* for its balanced package of good performance, acceptable features, sensible pricing and terrific after sales support (unit level replacement and ready availability of consumables).

### Small Work Group Laser Printers

Brother's HL-2170W, Canon's LBP-3300, Samsung's 2850D and HP's 1505 are the contenders in the small work group laser printer category.

### Features

Let's begin with Brother's HL-2170W. This was the only laser

printer to offer maximum connectivity options. It offers wireless connectivity via 802.11 b/g protocol and have Ethernet as well as USB 2.0. Setting up the Wi-Fi is easy and can be done via the settings panel, and can be secured using the strong WAP2 protocol. Brother should consider offering a higher capacity paper cassette as optional though.

Canon's LBP-3300 has a vertical design profile and hence requires less desk space. The base model doesn't come with Ethernet but it is available as option. Dual-side printing is offered as standard. The paper tray holds 250 sheets, but with dual-side printing one can print 500 pages.

Samsung's ML-2850D sports the familiar boxy design but the use of good looking materials gives it a pleasing look. Samsung offers optional 250 paper cassette and 128 MB memory upgrade.

The HP P1505 sports larger dimensions, but designed cleverly to look good on a desktop. The P1505 is the base version and comes with just 2 MB of memory, but the higher spec P1505n comes with 8 MB of memory and Ethernet inbuilt.

### Performance

HP's P1505 took the performance crown in the speed test by delivering printouts at sensational speeds. First page came in record breaking 6 seconds flat. The combi-document which generally takes 14 seconds to get printed was delivered in just 9 seconds. Samsung's ML-2850D came in second place as far as speed is concerned and averaged about 10 seconds on various speed tests we put it through. Canon's LBP-3300 and Brother's HL-2170W were neck and neck, and in most of the tests Canon was ahead by small margin of 2 seconds.

HP continued its dominance in the print quality test too, delivering crisp printouts. Finer details were faithfully reproduced. The grey scale gradients, graphs, lines, concentric patterns were printed immaculately without jarring edges. Samsung's ML-2850D was equally impressive as HP and delivered near sharp print-

outs. Canon's LBP-3300 and brother were locked in a close battle for the printout quality too. In some test Brother was marginally ahead of the Canon and in some Canon dominated but none of these two could match HP or Samsung.

HP's laserJet P1505 takes away the *Best Buy* award due to its terrific performance and sensible pricing, not to mention the wide after sales support HP has pan India. Samsung's ML-2850D also makes a good buy if you are willing to spend a thousand more for the dual-side printing and future upgrades.

## Inkjet Printers

### Home & SOHO printers

### Features

In this category we had six such products which fit our criteria. Two printers each from HP, Canon and Epson.

The Stylus T11 is the newest in the extensive range of printers from Epson and the cheapest printer available on the market. Neatly designed the exterior panels show no signs of cost cutting, in fact it looks upmarket and would definitely appeal to a large audience. Under the hood, the T11 comes with meagre 32KB of memory and it is USB 1.1 compatible; not the recipe for fast printing.

HP 910 comes from the small cute looking series it had introduced a couple of years ago, but still retains the charm. Compact, laced with right kind features the HP 910 surely makes for a good home printer atleast on paper. It has 384 KB of memory and interfaces using full speed USB 2.0.

Canon's iP2580 is the smallest baby in the PIXMA range of printers known for their terrific print speed and equally impressive print quality. The iP2580 is beautifully designed and the exterior are classy for this category of products. The iP2580 uses Canon's CAPT technology to good use and relies completely on your system memory for delivering printouts at unbelievable speeds.

All three printers above are entry level devices from respec-



HP P1007

tive vendors and are devoid of any frills such as memory card readers, PictBridge, direct CD printing, etc. Moving a step ahead we have Canon's iP-3500, Epson's Stylus C110 and HP's PS-D5368 offering few more features which would appeal to the SoHo audience.

Canon's iP3500 is a step up from the entry level iP 2580, and offers some additional features. Designed in much the same way as other PIXMA range of printers—boxy yet good looking due to use of translucent material. The iP-3500 also has dual paper path wherein paper can be fed from the top as well as the both cassette. Auto dual-side printing feature isn't available though. The printer is PictBridge compatible and interfaces via USB 2.0.

HP's PS D5368 as the name implies comes from the PhotoSmart series which are



HP P1505

capable of printing photographs. Amongst the three printers here, the HP PS D5368 is loaded with utility features. First, it comes with a small LCD display which helps in printing photographs without connecting it to a PC. It has inbuilt memory card reader to do so, but doesn't support PictBridge. Second it features dual-side printing and hence would save lot of paper in the longer run. Third, HP has provided a tray for printing directly in CD/DVD, albeit you need media

which support direct printing.

Epson's C110 is the typical non-sense office printer with the right mix of feature and performance. We did like to see Epson to include dual side printing support for it to be the perfect office printer. Apart from faster print engine and more memory there is hardly any other feature it offers over the Stylus T11.

### Performance

Coming to print speed, Canon's iP2580 literally murders HP 910 and Epson stylus T11. In some test such as the photograph printing, the difference is staggering—6 minutes to be precise. We have seen the PIXMA print engine blew the competition away in our earliest test and hence this result wasn't any surprise to us. Between HP 910 and Epson T11, HP is much speedier. In the photograph printing test the Epson stylus T11 took 9 minutes to deliver the printout, when HP 910 did it in 5 minutes and Canon iP-2580 took just 3 minutes. One thing to remember though is these printers will rarely be used for such heavy printing. They are meant for light text and graphics.

Image quality is HP's playground and the 910 doesn't disappoint. The text printouts are flawless with hardly any jarring edges or smudges. The colour printouts are vibrant and saturation is perfect. The photograph we printed was reproduced as is with hardly any tonal deviation. Interestingly, Epson's T11 does better job than Canon's iP-2580, though both are equally matched when printing text, the same cannot be said when printing graphics. Overall, it was HP 910 which delivered exceptional results in the print quality test.

In the SOHO category, Canon's iP-3500 sets the benchmark for printing speed and delivers the fastest printout. However, in this category the other two contenders from HP and Epson are fast enough and are behind by smaller margins as compared to the home category of printers. Epson's Stylus C110 is ahead of both Canon and HP when printing text documents, it's only when printing large graphic files